

A DINNER PARTY

A short film screenplay

Example script for AI pre-production tools

Written in standard screenplay format

INT. VALE HOUSE - HALLWAY - NIGHT

A rain-darkened HALLWAY. A grandfather clock ticks with ceremonial patience. On a narrow table: a cream INVITATION CARD, a MATCHBOX, and a small PORCELAIN BIRD with one chipped wing.

MAYA HOLT, 31, enters with a coat damp from rain and a gaze that takes inventory before it takes comfort. She carries a small bag with her vintage camera inside.

ELEANOR VALE, 50s, appears at the far end of the hall as if she has been standing there long before the doorbell rang.

ELEANOR

You found us.

MAYA

The house seems determined to be found.

ELEANOR

Most old houses are. They pretend to hide, then punish you for looking.

Eleanor notices Maya glance at the invitation card.

MAYA

There was no sender.

ELEANOR

And yet you came.

MAYA

Anonymous invitations are either dangerous or irresistible.

ELEANOR

Tonight we are trying for polite.

JULIAN VALE, 52, steps in from the dining room. Warm smile, tired eyes, cufflinks too careful for the hour.

JULIAN

Maya Holt. The documentarian.

MAYA

That depends who is asking.

JULIAN

Tonight I am only a husband apologizing for the weather.

MAYA

Did you arrange that as well?

JULIAN

In this house, Eleanor is usually
blamed for atmosphere.

ROSE VALE, 19, slides down the staircase, barefoot,
wearing a dress that looks borrowed from a portrait and
resenting it.

ROSE

She arranged the rain for dramatic
continuity.

ELEANOR

Rose, shoes.

ROSE

Manners first, shoes later. That is
the family motto, right?

THEO KING, 35, the private chef, crosses the hall with a
SERVING TRAY. He pauses as if he has walked into a scene
mid-take.

THEO

If anyone asks, the kitchen is calm
and the soup believes in us.

MAYA

I keep thinking the invitation was
too formal for dinner. Heavy paper,
ink, no signature. It felt less
like an invitation and more like
evidence.

ELEANOR

Evidence requires a crime. Tonight
only requires appetite and manners.

ROSE

Then we are already in trouble.
Nobody in this house has both.

JULIAN

Rose.

ROSE

What? I included myself.

Maya lifts her bag. The outline of the vintage CAMERA
presses against the canvas.

ELEANOR

No filming tonight.

MAYA

I was not told there would be rules.

ELEANOR

That is because rules are most useful when discovered late.

A beat. The clock ticks. Rose looks from Maya to her mother, alert to a voltage she does not understand.

JULIAN

Dinner is ready enough. Shall we?

CUT TO:

INT. VALE HOUSE - DINING ROOM - NIGHT

The DINING ROOM is candlelit to the point of confession. A long table: three-arm CANDELABRA, CRYSTAL GLASSES, red WINE BOTTLE, and handwritten PLACE CARDS written in a graceful hand.

Five places are set. A sixth chair at the far end is empty but prepared with a napkin folded like a surrender flag.

ROSE

There are six places.

ELEANOR

There have always been six places.

JULIAN

Not always.

Eleanor looks at him. The room cools around the candles.

MAYA

Should I not sit?

ELEANOR

You should sit exactly where your card tells you to sit.

Maya finds her card. MAYA. Next to ROSE. Across from JULIAN. ELEANOR at the head. THEO sets plates from the sideboard.

THEO

I am staff tonight, not family.
Which is safer and better paid.

ROSE

You are also the only person here
who can legally hold a knife.

Theo glances toward the sideboard where the silver CARVING
KNIFE shines beside a folded napkin.

JULIAN

Maya, you said you were making a
film about disappearing houses.

MAYA

About houses that keep the people
inside them long after the people
leave.

ROSE

That sounds like this house. It
remembers better than we do.

ELEANOR

Houses do not remember. People
project.

MAYA

People leave marks. Projection is
just another kind of light.

Eleanor pours wine. The red catches in each glass like a
small injury.

JULIAN

A toast. To... returning friends.

MAYA

We have never met.

JULIAN

Then to future corrections.

ROSE

That sounds expensive.

ELEANOR

To dinner.

They drink. Maya watches the untouched sixth glass.

MAYA

Who is the empty chair for?

ELEANOR

Tradition.

ROSE

That is not a person.

ELEANOR

In this house it nearly is.

ROSE

Why is there a place card for
someone who is dead?

ELEANOR

Because your grandmother believed
absence deserved a seat.

JULIAN

Eleanor.

ROSE

No, let her answer. The card says
A. Vale. Not Grandmother. Not
Agnes. Just the initial.

MAYA

May I see it?

ELEANOR

No.

Rose reaches for the place card near the empty chair.
Eleanor catches her wrist. Not hard. Worse: intimately
precise.

ELEANOR

Do not make a scene before the
first course.

ROSE

Then schedule the truth for
dessert.

THEO

Soup first.

Theo enters with the SOUP TUREEN. Steam curls from it like
an idea trying to leave.

CUT TO:

INT. VALE HOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

The KITCHEN is bright, practical, and less honest than it looks. Theo lifts lids, checks pans, and moves with focused calm. On the counter: herbs, a SERVING TRAY, a CAKE BOX, and a drawer that refuses to close.

Rose enters carrying two empty plates like shields.

THEO

If you are escaping, the back door sticks.

ROSE

I am not escaping. I am reconnaissance.

THEO

Reconnaissance usually wears shoes.

ROSE

Espionage evolves.

Theo notices her staring at the drawer.

THEO

Do not open that.

ROSE

That is the first thing anyone says before something interesting.

She opens it. Inside: linen, a corkscrew, and a BRASS KEY half-wrapped in a dish towel.

THEO

I found this key under the onions.

JULIAN

Under the onions?

THEO

I do not judge where families hide their truths. I only need the counter space.

ELEANOR

Give it to me.

ROSE

That is the first honest sentence anyone has said tonight.

Theo places the key on the counter between them. Rose does

not touch it.

ROSE

What does it open?

THEO

In my experience, trouble.
Occasionally pantries.

ROSE

The pantry has a normal key.

THEO

Then trouble is favored.

Maya enters with the pretense of needing water. Her eyes move to the brass key immediately.

MAYA

Am I interrupting?

ROSE

Yes. Please continue.

MAYA

I saw the empty chair. The
initials. A. Vale.

THEO

I focus on proteins, not ghosts.

ROSE

Agnes Vale. My grandmother. She
died before I was born. Officially
upstairs. Unofficially everywhere.

MAYA

And the key?

ROSE

Every house has a locked room. We
just have better lighting.

Julian appears in the doorway. His charm has not followed him from the dining room.

JULIAN

Rose. Back to the table.

ROSE

Do you know what this opens?

JULIAN

I know that dinner is cooling.

MAYA

That was almost an answer.

JULIAN

Miss Holt, you mistake invitation
for permission.

MAYA

Occupational hazard.

Julian takes the key. He does not ask Theo why it was
there. Theo notes that.

CUT TO:

INT. VALE HOUSE - DINING ROOM - LATER

The soup bowls are half-empty. Conversation has become
careful in the way a cracked floor is careful.

Maya has placed her vintage CAMERA on the table beside her
glass. The lens points at nobody and accuses everyone.

MAYA

The camera is not recording.

ELEANOR

It still changes the room.

MAYA

So does a locked drawer. So does a
name nobody says.

JULIAN

We invited you for dinner, not an
interrogation.

MAYA

Usually dinner does the
interrogating by itself.

Eleanor touches the pearls at her throat. Rose clocks the
movement.

ROSE

Mom, why are you wearing her
pearls?

ELEANOR

Because they are mine now.

ROSE

That is not an answer. That is inheritance pretending to be grammar.

THEO

The roast is ready.

JULIAN

Thank God.

Theo enters with the roast on a tray. Julian reaches for the carving knife. It is not there.

THEO

Someone has moved the carving knife.

ROSE

That is not ominous at all.

ELEANOR

It was by the tray.

JULIAN

It was not.

MAYA

How quickly certainty arrives when memory is embarrassed.

THEO

I set it next to the roast. Silver handle. Very judgmental.

MAYA

Objects do not disappear. People relocate them.

ELEANOR

Are you writing that down?

MAYA

No. I am remembering it incorrectly in advance.

Rose laughs despite herself. Eleanor does not.

JULIAN

I will get another knife.

ELEANOR

No.

JULIAN

Eleanor, the roast needs carving.

ELEANOR

Then it can remain whole.

A silence. The statement lands strangely, as if she meant something else entirely.

ROSE

That is the saddest thing anyone
has ever said about meat.

Maya notices an sealed ENVELOPE tucked beneath the empty
place setting. Wax seal. No name.

MAYA

There is an envelope.

ELEANOR

Leave it.

ROSE

For Agnes?

JULIAN

Rose, enough.

ROSE

No. The dead got a chair, a glass,
and mail. I got a dress that itches
and no explanation.

Maya lifts the envelope. Eleanor stands. Candle flames
tremble as if taking a side.

ELEANOR

Put it down.

MAYA

It is already open.

JULIAN

It cannot be.

It is. The seal has been sliced. Cleanly.

CUT TO:

INT. VALE HOUSE - HALLWAY - NIGHT

Maya slips into the hallway with the envelope. Rose
follows, thrilled and terrified. The dining room murmurs
behind them.

Inside the envelope: an OLD PHOTOGRAPH. A young Eleanor. A younger Julian. A woman who must be Agnes. On Agnes' lap: a baby with Rose's eyes.

ROSE

That is impossible.

MAYA

Photographs are rude that way.

ROSE

That baby is not me. I was born years after she died.

MAYA

Then either the date is wrong or the story is.

Rose turns the photograph over. Written in blue ink: FOR THE DINNER WHEN SHE ASKS.

ROSE

She who?

MAYA

You.

ROSE

No. I would remember being planned by a ghost.

The clock ticks. Maya listens, then notices a narrow door beneath the stairs. A keyhole.

MAYA

Where does that lead?

ROSE

Old coat closet. Locked for years.

MAYA

Do you still want to know what the key opens?

ROSE

I want to not want to.

Julian appears, holding the brass key.

JULIAN

Give me the photograph.

ROSE

Why? So you can hide it better?

JULIAN

So I can explain before you make it cruel.

MAYA

Truth does not become cruel because it arrives with witnesses.

JULIAN

That is exactly how truth becomes cruel.

Eleanor enters from the dining room. Her pearls shine at her throat like arranged teeth.

ELEANOR

Open it.

JULIAN

No.

ELEANOR

The dinner was for this. You wanted ritual. Ritual has teeth.

Julian looks at the key in his hand. The hallway seems to narrow around him.

CUT TO:

INT. VALE HOUSE - HALLWAY CLOSET - CONTINUOUS

The door opens with a sound like breath returning to a lung. Inside is not a closet. It is a tiny archive: boxes, garment bags, and a narrow writing desk.

On the desk: the locked DIARY, a pair of WHITE GLOVES, the missing silver CARVING KNIFE, and a BROKEN WATCH stopped at 8:17.

ROSE

You locked a room inside a hallway.

ELEANOR

We locked a night inside a room.

MAYA

The diary.

JULIAN

There is nothing in that diary that will help anyone.

MAYA

Help is not the only reason people open things.

ELEANOR

Curiosity is a vulgar costume for greed.

ROSE

Then the whole family came dressed.

Theo appears behind them, wiping his hands on a towel, drawn by the gravity of withheld information.

THEO

The roast is cold.

ROSE

Everything is cold.

Eleanor reaches for the white gloves. She pulls them on carefully before touching the diary.

ELEANOR

Your grandmother kept notes about everyone. Gifts she gave. Debts she collected. Pain she mistook for discipline.

ROSE

Why keep it?

JULIAN

Because burning it did not make what happened less true.

MAYA

What happened at 8:17?

Julian picks up the broken watch. His thumb rubs the cracked face.

JULIAN

Agnes fell down the stairs.

ROSE

Officially.

ELEANOR

She was pushed.

No one breathes.

ROSE

By who?

ELEANOR

By me.

The words do not explode. They settle, heavy, on every object in the closet.

JULIAN

Eleanor.

ELEANOR

I was twenty. Pregnant. Terrified.
She said the child would be taken.
That the family would absorb the
scandal and erase the mother.

ROSE

The child in the photo.

MAYA

Your sister?

ELEANOR

Your mother.

ROSE

What?

Eleanor cannot look at Rose. Julian can. It is worse.

CUT TO:

INT. VALE HOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

Rose stands at the kitchen sink, gripping the edge. Water runs though nobody washes anything. Maya keeps distance. Theo repacks the cake box with inappropriate care.

ROSE

Say it simply. I need one simple sentence.

MAYA

Eleanor raised you, but she did not give birth to you.

ROSE

That was not simple. That was a room collapsing with grammar.

THEO

Drink water.

ROSE

Do not chef me.

THEO

Hydration is neutral.

Maya sets the old photograph on the counter. Rose studies the baby, then the young woman holding it.

ROSE

Who was she?

MAYA

The woman in the photo?

ROSE

My mother. The biological one. I hate that phrase. It sounds like a specimen jar.

THEO

Her name might be in the diary.

ROSE

Of course. My whole life reduced to an index.

Julian enters, stopped by the sight of Rose and the photograph.

JULIAN

Her name was Clara.

ROSE

Was.

JULIAN

She died when you were eleven months old.

ROSE

And you all decided I needed a better story?

JULIAN

We decided you needed a mother who would stay.

ROSE

Eleanor stayed by deleting her.

JULIAN

Eleanor stayed because I asked her to.

Eleanor appears. She has removed the pearls. They hang in her hand.

ELEANOR

Because I wanted to.

ROSE

Did you love me, or did you love the chance to fix what you did?

ELEANOR

Both. I am sorry that both is the honest answer.

Maya's MOBILE PHONE vibrates on the counter. She ignores it. The room notices that she ignores it.

JULIAN

Who is calling?

MAYA

My producer.

ELEANOR

So there is a film.

MAYA

There was a possibility.

ROSE

Were you invited here to film us?

MAYA

No. I was invited because Clara wrote me six months ago.

The phone continues to vibrate. No one moves.

CUT TO:

INT. VALE HOUSE - DINING ROOM - NIGHT

They return to the table as if the table might impose order. It does not. The roast sits uncarved. The empty chair is no longer empty in anyone's mind.

The pearl necklace lies beside the three-arm CANDELABRA. The broken watch is by Rose's plate. The sealed envelope is open. The carving knife has been returned, blade clean.

MAYA

Clara was alive six months ago.

JULIAN

No.

MAYA

She used another name. She sent me records. Hospital transfers, guardianship forms, letters she never mailed.

ELEANOR

She died.

MAYA

You were told she died.

ROSE

By who?

Everyone looks at the empty chair. Agnes, absent and present, wins again.

JULIAN

Agnes said the funeral was private. She said Clara had no family left.

ELEANOR

She lied from the grave before she even entered it.

THEO

That is a talent.

ROSE

Do not make me laugh. I will hate you.

THEO

Fair.

Maya removes a folded letter from her bag. Different paper. Modern. Worn from rereading.

MAYA

Clara asked me to bring this only if Rose wanted the truth.

ROSE

How would she know?

MAYA

She said people who grow up around
locked rooms always do.

Maya offers the letter. Rose does not take it. Eleanor
reaches out, then stops herself.

ELEANOR

It is yours.

ROSE

Everything tonight is mine once it
has ruined me.

JULIAN

Rose, please.

ROSE

No. I want one person to say what
they want without decorating it.

Silence. Then Eleanor stands at the head of the table.

ELEANOR

When a family survives, people call
it dignity. When it fails, they
call it truth.

ROSE

I would rather fail honestly.

JULIAN

You say that because you have never
had to keep a roof over shame.

MAYA

Roofs leak. Shame floods.

ELEANOR

I want you to read it. I want you
to hate me accurately. I want the
story to stop eating you in the
dark.

Rose takes the letter.

CUT TO:

INT. VALE HOUSE - HALLWAY - LATER

The dinner has ended without anyone leaving. The hallway

holds coats, damp umbrellas, and the feeling of a verdict not yet delivered.

Rose stands by the front door with Clara's letter open. Maya waits near the small table. The porcelain bird faces the wall now.

ROSE

She says she tried to come back.

MAYA

Yes.

ROSE

She says Agnes sent her away. Paid a doctor. Changed records. Made her look unstable.

MAYA

Yes.

ROSE

She says Eleanor wrote once.

Maya looks toward the dining room, where Eleanor is visible in a slice of candlelight.

MAYA

Did she?

ROSE

She says the letter saved her life because it proved someone in this house knew she existed.

Rose folds the letter carefully, as if care can compensate for years.

ROSE

Why did Clara contact you?

MAYA

She saw my film about the orphanage in Kent. She recognized the pattern. Records broken, names softened, women edited out.

ROSE

And she wanted a film.

MAYA

She wanted a witness. Those are different until someone points a camera.

Eleanor enters the hall. No pearls. No gloves. Smaller and more dangerous for it.

ELEANOR

Is she alive?

MAYA

Yes.

ELEANOR

Where?

MAYA

That is for Rose to ask, not you.

Eleanor accepts this. It costs her.

ROSE

Do you want me to meet her?

ELEANOR

Yes.

ROSE

That was fast.

ELEANOR

I have had nineteen years to arrive at it.

Julian comes from the dining room carrying the untouched cake box.

JULIAN

Theo says dessert travels better than most revelations.

ROSE

We are not taking cake to my resurrected mother.

JULIAN

Noted.

For the first time tonight, everyone almost smiles.

CUT TO:

INT. VALE HOUSE - DINING ROOM - DAWN

Dawn presses weak blue light into the dining room. Candles have burned into wax lakes. The table is wreckage: glasses, plates, the old photograph, the place cards, the

diary.

Maya sets her camera on the table. This time she does not ask permission. This time no one stops her.

MAYA

I am turning it on.

ROSE

Do we have to look into it?

MAYA

Only if you want to be seen.

THEO

I prefer off-camera honesty. It requires less powder.

Theo gathers plates. Eleanor stops him.

ELEANOR

Leave the table.

THEO

Professionally, that hurts.

ELEANOR

Let it show what happened.

Maya presses RECORD. A tiny red light appears.

MAYA

State your name.

ELEANOR

Eleanor Vale.

MAYA

And what is this room?

ELEANOR

The place where we mistook silence for protection.

MAYA

Rose?

ROSE

Rose Vale. For now.

JULIAN

You do not have to decide that today.

ROSE

I know. That is why I said for now.

Maya pans to the table. The camera sees the candelabra, the open diary, the brass key, the empty chair. Objects as testimony.

MAYA

What should the film be called?

THEO

Cold Roast.

ROSE

Absolutely not.

JULIAN

The Sixth Place.

ELEANOR

A Dinner Party.

They sit with that. It is plain enough to hold everything.

ROSE

A dinner party has guests.

MAYA

And an ending.

ROSE

Not yet.

Rose takes the place card marked A. VALE and turns it over. On the back, she writes CLARA with a fountain pen. The ink bleeds slightly into the paper.

ROSE

Now it has a beginning.

Maya's camera catches Eleanor watching Rose write the name. Eleanor does not forgive herself. She does something harder. She stays present.

Theo opens the cake box. The cake has collapsed on one side. Somehow it is still beautiful.

THEO

Breakfast?

ROSE

That is not breakfast.

THEO

After a night like this, categories
are ceremonial.

Julian cuts the cake with the carving knife. No one
flinches. That, too, is a kind of progress.

MAYA

One more question.

ELEANOR

There is always one more question.

MAYA

What do you want now?

Eleanor looks at Rose. Rose looks at the new name on the
place card. Julian looks at the door. Theo looks at the
cake because someone should.

ROSE

I want to meet Clara. I want to
decide slowly. I want nobody to
make my life neat for their
conscience.

JULIAN

I can do slowly.

ELEANOR

I can learn.

THEO

I can pack cake.

MAYA

Then that is where we end.

But she does not stop recording yet. The family sits in
the ruined elegance of the dining room, passing paper
plates, the camera watching not the secret but the first
ordinary thing after it.

Outside, the rain has stopped. The house does not forgive.
It exhales.

FADE OUT.

THE END